



PTI PHOTO

Naveen Patnaik

BJD

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- His divorce from the NDA helps him to wash off the blame of Kandhamal violence.
- Can emerge as the prime ministerial candidate if things work his way.
- His reputation as a clean leader will come to his aid.

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- By breaking away from the BJP, he may face tough competition in the three-faced contest.
- Runs the risk of giving away power in Orissa if his calculations go wrong.
- May be forced to go back to the BJP for support.

Sugreev syndrome" (The story of sibling rivalry in the Ramayan). Mamata cannot share power with the Comrades; Mulayam can't ever do business with Mayawati, no joint venture between Jaya and Karunanidhi. These rivalries will force many regional parties to stick with the Third Front and avoid natural foes. So, if Mulayam wants to sup with the Congress, don't expect Maya to be at the table. Still, in all likelihood, the pre-election braggadocio will be replaced by post-May 16 opportunism. As it's not a front united by ideology or a common minimum programme, everything will depend on the terms of power sharing. What about their economic philosophy? Or, what are their foreign policy priorities? We have no idea, though we know that all of them don't share the worldview of Comrade Karat. Remember, none of these Front-runners suffers from modesty and all of them float in prime ministe-

WHAT ABOUT THEIR ECONOMIC PHILOSOPHY? OR, WHAT ARE THEIR FOREIGN POLICY PRIORITIES? INDIA IS YET TO KNOW.

rial fantasies. King or kingmakers—and there is nothing in between for these grandees and divas. If they cannot wield the ultimate power, they will dictate power, for either of the national parties can't form the government without regional support. And if they manage to get the magical number, it could be Deve Gowda or V.P. Singh all over again. They should also know a thing or two about the durability of power with Congress support. Chandra Shekhar, former prime minister and a victim of Congress support, had famously confessed: "I am not the

great moral alternative before the nation, my friend. I don't have the newspapers backing me. I am just an ordinary politician who compromises with everyone." Today no Third Front or Fourth Front veteran is likely to make such a statement of self-deprecation. They are extraordinary brokers with stupendous moral elasticity in the power bazaar. If they can't sell an alternative, come May 16 and each of them will sell himself to the highest bidder.

with Amarnath K. Menon, Stephen David and Anand Nataraajan

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